to admit that India was a victim of cross-border terrorism. Troops were amassed on the India–Pakistan border, war seemed imminent and there was even talk of nuclear bombs.

In the midst of this war against terror, the government arranged a joint meeting of the two houses of Parliament to pass the Prevention of Terrorism Act (POTA).[2] It would require rare courage for anyone to question the efficacy of POTA a few weeks after the attack on Parliament. It would be blatantly anti-national and unpatriotic. And thus India joined the ‘war against terror’.

In Delhi University the ‘ultranationalist’ forces demanded that the services of S.A.R. Geelani, a lecturer at Zakir Hussain College and one of the four accused of being a part of the conspiracy to attack Parliament, be terminated. They said there was no need to wait for the trial to begin. After all, even respectable newspapers had carried screaming tabloid-style headlines that Geelani had confessed to being a part of the conspiracy.[3] Besides, he was a Kashmiri Muslim and taught Arabic. What more proof could anyone want of his complicity in the conspiracy?

The media of course did not carry any report of the fact that despite use of torture by the police to extort a confession, Geelani had refused to admit to his guilt. No one questioned the Special Branch’s blatantly false claims that Geelani had made a confession.

In the midst of this environment of prejudice and hatred, a group of Zakir Hussain College teachers worked quietly but consistently to oppose the forces of fascism and prevent Geelani’s services from being terminated. Some Delhi University teachers came together to address issues arising out of Geelani’s trial. A few visited Geelani in jail, even though they did not know him personally. Others fought long and hard to win the support of the teachers’ unions. Unfortunately, the unions even hesitated to issue a statement demanding a fair trial for a member accused of a terrorist act.

There was a small group of citizens, including veteran socialists, civil liberty activists and democratic Indians, who were deeply concerned over the fact that the new anti-terrorist law made it virtually impossible for any accused to prove his innocence. And they believed Geelani when he said he was innocent.

The challenge before this small but committed group of Indian citizens was how to turn public opinion—to make people aware of the dangers of convicting people merely on the basis of police suspicion, without a fair trial